Morality Without a Divine Test

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Abstract. This essay considers the claim that the felt structure of moral life supports the idea of a divine test. It distinguishes the experiences of temptation, guilt, sacrifice, and suffering from interpretations that assign them an external examiner. The discussion compares proposed psychological and social explanations with the explanatory demands placed on a test hypothesis, then asks what can make responsibility matter without an appeal to final judgment. Its conclusion concerns the limits of one argument for divine purpose and does not settle the wider question of God's existence.



Johannes Vermeer, Woman Holding a Balance. National Gallery of Art, Widener Collection. Public-domain reproduction via Wikimedia Commons.

"The person you betray stays betrayed whether or not anyone tallies it in a book you read after you die." Sohel Georgiadis 12 Dec 2025

1. Moral experience and explanation

If atheism is true and life is not a test from God, then why does human existence feel so deeply structured around moral choices, patience, suffering, temptation, sacrifice, guilt, repentance, and the constant pressure to choose between what is easy and what is right?

Read the question again, slower and understand what you have said. Don't let the mechanism jump in too early and steal the ache before you've actually felt it. Something in that sentence is true no matter who wins this argument: the fork in the hallway, the small cowardice you know the shape of before you commit it, the guilt that parks itself in your chest at 2 a.m. and won't leave when you ask it politely. Nobody gets to explain that away with a shrug or loud voice. Nor the imam. Nor the confident man online who thinks Dawkins closed the case in 2006. The ache stays real regardless of who wins.

So do the hard thing first. Hold the ache in one hand and the story about the ache in the other, and refuse to let them fuse. "Life feels like a test" is the ache. "Life is a test, administered by Allah, for the purpose of sorting you before judgment" is the story riding on the ache's back. The question smuggles the second thing in wearing the first thing's coat. That's the oldest move in every scripture ever written, and it works because the ache is loud enough that you don't notice the story climbing onto it.

No, that's too easy. Say it properly. This isn't some priest in a back room cynically deciding to fool people. It's older and sadder than that. Someone, somewhere, felt this exact ache as hard as you feel it now, could not bear that it might mean nothing, and reached for the only shape big enough to hold it: an examiner, a book, a reckoning waiting on the other side of death. I understand the reach. I've made it myself, in weaker hours, at the edge of sleep. Understanding it is not the same as letting it stand unexamined.

2. Temptation, guilt and suffering

Start with the body, because that's where temptation actually lives, not in some abstract battlefield of angels and devils. You are not one thing arguing with itself about whether to lie. You are two systems wearing the same skin. One is old and fast, built for the reward sitting right in front of you. The other is newer and slower, built to weigh a reward that hasn't arrived yet against one that already has. Walter Mischel put four year olds in a room with a marshmallow and a promise, wait and you get two. Some waited. Some didn't. What decided it wasn't willpower as some mystical inner substance, it was how far the slow system had developed against the fast one, and it tracked, years later, into the rest of those children's lives. That's temptation. Two clocks in one skull running at different speeds, and you living in the gap between them. Patience is just that same slow clock winning, for once. It isn't a virtue handed down from outside. It's a rigged fight your own biology runs every day, and some days the old system wins instead, and you call that day weakness. It is. But it's your weakness, built in your own skull, not a failed exam graded by someone watching from outside time.

Guilt, look at its shape before you look at its cause, because the shape gives it away. Guilt doesn't fire evenly. It doesn't punish you the same amount for cheating a stranger you'll never see again as it does for betraying someone who trusted you for ten years. If guilt were the footprint of a divine law, universal, written once for everyone, you'd expect it to answer to the rule. It doesn't. It answers to the relationship. Robert Trivers worked out why in 1971: cooperation between people who aren't kin only survives if cheats get caught, and if something inside the cheat pushes hard enough to force repair before the group cuts him loose. Guilt is that push. Not a summons from outside you. An alarm your own species installed, because the version of us that had it out-trusted and outlasted the version that didn't. Repentance is just guilt finishing its own sentence, the visible proof that the alarm did its job and something actually changed.

Sacrifice runs on the same math from a different door. Cheap gestures get faked, so people stop trusting them. A gift that costs you something real, time you don't get back, comfort you actually needed, is expensive precisely because it can't be faked cheaply, and that's exactly why it moves people. You don't need a watching god to explain why the widow's coin lands harder than the rich man's excess. You need a species that learned, brutally, over a long time, to tell real cost from performance, because the ones who couldn't got exploited out of existence.

And suffering, the heaviest one on the list, the one that actually breaks people rather than just troubling them. Suffering doesn't need a purpose assigned to it to be real, and it doesn't become less real for lacking one. A body in pain is a body signaling damage so you protect the wound. Nothing about the wound requires an audience. The insistence that suffering must be for something isn't a fact about the wound. It's a need in the person staring at it, unable to tolerate that it might be pointless.

Fine. Say all of that clicks into place cleanly, mechanism after mechanism, each one holding. There is still something underneath that won't sit down, and I won't pretend it does. Knowing guilt is an evolved alarm doesn't make the alarm quieter at 2 a.m. Knowing why the ache exists is not the same as making it leave, and anyone who tells you otherwise has swapped one comfort for another and called it a victory. I'm not interested in that swap. I want the true account, even if the true account still leaves me lying awake.

3. The test and its alternatives

Here's where the actual trick happens, and it's worth slowing down for, because most people walk straight past it. Ask what the test claim would look like if it were false. Try to build the failure case. Life soaked in guilt and struggle, that's the test. Life mostly ease and comfort, also the test, a test of whether comfort corrupts you. You suffer badly while someone else barely suffers at all, still the test, patience assigned to you, mercy assigned to them. A man commits real evil and never feels a flicker of guilt for any of it, even that gets folded back in, a hardened heart, still inside the story, still counted as evidence for it rather than against it. Look closer. There is no outcome the

claim can't eat and call confirmation. David Deutsch has a name for what that means: a good explanation is hard to vary, every part of it pinned to something specific, so that changing one detail breaks the whole thing in your hands. A bad explanation survives no matter what you feed it, because none of its parts were ever load bearing to begin with. "Life is a test" is not hard to vary. It's the softest explanation available. It bends around every fact you throw at it and calls the bending proof. That isn't strength. It's the opposite of strength, wearing the costume of certainty.

And it isn't only Islam wearing this costume, which should bother you more than it probably does. Job gets stripped to nothing and tested for the quality of his faith, and that story predates the Quran by a long stretch. Christianity inherits the whole architecture, temptation, sin, repentance, judgment, and redresses it in its own vocabulary. Hinduism doesn't even need a single test, it stretches the sorting across lifetimes, karma as residue, every choice paid out later in a body you won't remember having. Buddhism goes further and removes the examiner completely: dukkha, the built-in wrongness of existence, met by discipline, by the eightfold path, no god required to hand out a grade at the end. Same ache. Wildly different costumes, one of them with no face behind the mask at all. If the ache were really one author's fingerprint, you'd expect it to point at him and go silent everywhere else. It doesn't go silent anywhere. That isn't what a signature looks like. That's what a universal human structure looks like, dressed locally in whatever theology happened to be standing nearby when someone needed the ache explained.

Jonathan Haidt's cross-cultural work on moral intuition lands the same blow from another angle. Certain foundations show up almost everywhere he looked: care for the vulnerable, a sense of fairness, loyalty to your own, respect for earned authority, disgust at what feels unclean. What shifts, hard, culture to culture, is how much weight lands on each one and what specific acts get filed under which heading. That's the signature of an evolved architecture wearing regional clothing. It is not the signature of one revealed law dimly glimpsed by everyone else and fully seen by one chosen group. If there really were one answer key handed down once, you wouldn't expect this much variation in the substance. Maybe in the packaging. Not underneath it.

4. Responsibility without a scorekeeper

Now give the argument its full weight, because there's a real version of it with actual teeth, not a strawman built to fall over on command. The strongest form isn't even specifically Islamic. C. S. Lewis opened Mere Christianity with something close to it: people everywhere argue about right and wrong as though arguing about a fact, not a taste. Nobody says "I simply prefer loyalty" the way they say "I simply prefer coffee." They say betrayal is wrong, flatly, the way they'd say a stone is hard. That flatness is itself a clue, the argument goes: if morality were only preference dressed up, why does it feel discovered instead of invented, binding instead of optional, the same weight pressing on a king as on a beggar. Add the test framework on top and it does one more

thing: it hands you a reason to choose the harder right when nothing is at stake and nobody's watching and the easy wrong costs you nothing. Take the test away and you still owe an answer to that last part. Why the harder right, if no one grades it, if the universe genuinely doesn't care which way you go. You don't get to wave that off with a citation. Answer it properly or admit you can't.

So answer it properly.

The flatness, fairness feeling like a discovered fact rather than a flavor, doesn't require an author standing outside us. It requires only that a mind experiencing morality as binding cooperates better than a mind experiencing it as negotiable. Picture the creature that treats fairness the way it treats a preference for one fruit over another: the moment betrayal turns convenient, it betrays, because nothing inside insists otherwise with any real force. That creature gets caught, gets punished, gets excluded, loses the long game against creatures whose moral sense fires like fact instead of taste, because the ones who feel it as fact behave more consistently and get trusted more and build alliances that actually hold. Selection doesn't care whether the feeling is metaphysically true. It only cares whether the feeling produces behavior that keeps the group alive. A false feeling that behaves exactly like a true one gets selected exactly as hard as a true one would. Which means the flatness cannot, by itself, tell you which story you're inside. A lawgiver produces that feeling. A ruthless, patient, godless selection process produces the identical feeling. Same data. Two stories underneath it. The feeling can't referee between them, so stop asking it to.

As for why you still choose the harder right when nobody's watching: you don't need a scorekeeper outside the universe for the choice to matter, because the people inside it are not outside it. The person you betray stays betrayed whether or not anyone tallies it in a book you read after you die. The trust you burn stays burnt. The room stays smaller for the people still standing in it. That isn't a lesser kind of stakes than judgment day. In some ways it's heavier, because there's no infinite mercy waiting afterward to absorb the wreckage. What you did is what happened. Full stop. No appeal, no next life to soften it, no waiting room where someone explains it to you gently. Sit with that before deciding atheism is the easy way out. It isn't. It's the version with no cushion under it.

5. The limits of the conclusion

So where does this land, once you stop being impressed by either side's confidence.

The ache is real. Keep that. Don't let anyone talk you out of it. But the story riding on top of it, that the specific shape of human moral struggle proves a specific test built by a specific god for a specific reckoning, fails on its own terms. Not because atheists are smarter. Because the claim doesn't survive contact with itself. It fails because mechanism predicts the ache in advance and the test explains it only after the fact, which is the difference between a theory and a narration written after the ending is already known. It fails because there's no outcome the claim can't absorb and rebrand

as proof, meaning it was never actually staked on anything. And it fails because the same ache turns up dressed in theologies that flatly contradict each other, one of them wearing no god at all, which is not what a fingerprint looks like.

That is not the same as saying Allah doesn't exist. Say that with care, because getting sloppy here would make this guilty of the exact crime it's prosecuting. This only shows one bridge collapsing, the bridge from "morality feels heavy" to "therefore a test-giver built the heaviness on purpose." Someone can still believe in God for reasons that never touched this bridge at all. What they don't get to do anymore, not honestly, is stand on this particular one and call it solid ground.

The guilt at 2 a.m. is not a summons. Nobody sent it. It's what a species that survived by trusting each other, generation after generation, with no one checking, feels like from the inside, in a room where no prayer was said and nothing answered back. The machinery doesn't care whether you believe in it. It was running before you were born. It'll be running in the next person lying awake after you're gone, under the same indifferent sky, asking the exact question you just asked, and arriving, if he's honest with himself, at roughly this same unfinished answer.

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